



Getting an award from ELCINA

ideas. In India, he had to bear the dust and heat of the field and sell his products and solutions as an applications engineer and returning to the plant to incorporate customer feedback into the next-gen products. Far from complaining about these differences, Sreeram thinks that this opportunity of meeting a wide variety of people across the country helped him grow professionally and in his career.

“Working in India has been entirely different from working in the United States. The wide exposure you get is better here in India than any other country,” says Sreeram.

## Turning businesses around

Sreeram, from his very first job in India, has been tasked with turning around the businesses. Starting with TVS, which was his first real job in the country, he was a part of the team that was responsible for helping the company acquire customers, develop new products, and burn less cash and become profitable in the shortest time possible. He says every company he has worked for in India since mid-90s has been a story of turnaround and looks like as if an invisible hand has led him to such opportunities as his destiny.

His love for numbers has probably also helped him in achieving his goals of profitable turnaround of the various businesses he has worked for. In fact, if not an engineer from IIT, he thinks he would have become an

accountant or a finance professional and got associated with something to do with numbers and accounting. “I love numbers and numbers get stuck in my mind as easily as it could,” explains Sreeram.

Sreeram says that every company he worked for was in the red in some way when he joined. He then had to work on new strategies, or quickly fine-tune existing strategies, to work out things and make the company profitable in a short time. In many cases, he recalls, the owners were, within a few weeks, forced to take a fresh look at the business and realise its importance to the overall scheme of things.

“Right from my first job in Hyderabad to my current job, I would typically go in when the situation was very very difficult and get the team to rally around on making things simpler and profitable. Probably I was destined for such things,” says Sreeram.

Sreeram, recalling his association with Saint Gobain, notes that he had joined the company at a difficult time—a new acquisition that was not doing well operationally and a huge investment in a greenfield facility in a different location. Sreeram and his team had to turnaround the business and simultaneously build a team afresh for the new greenfield plant. A five-fold profitable growth in six years resulted thanks to the dogged and spirited efforts of his teams. He says, he has only his team to thank for all this and thank himself only for staying out of their way!

Sreeram says, “I am not scared of meeting strangers and less-known people, and I can sit down and build rapport even in the worst of situations—a trait I credit to the wide variety of places I grew up in like Chattisgarh, Andhra Pradesh, Jharkhand, Tamil Nadu, and a few summer vacations in Jalandhar (Punjab) as well and the schooling in Kendriya Vidyalayas, where every classroom was a mini India. I think this is why I have been able to bond with my teams and also my bosses and get them to rally around or support my ideas.”

Apart from his research work in



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